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"WE CAN START WITH A JOINT PLANNING AND COORDINATION CENTRE AND SEE HOW IT PANS OUT. BUT DISRUPTING EVERYTHING AND MAKING ONE STRUCTURE NOW, I DO NOT THINK IT IS A VERY GOOD IDEA"

– AIR CHIEF MARSHAL A.P. SINGH, *Chief of Air Staff*

"THE NAVY IS COMMITTED TO 'THEATRISATION' AS THE ULTIMATE GOAL, AND SYNERGISING ITS COMMUNICATIONS AND COMBAT CAPABILITY WITH THE ARMY AND IAF"



– ADMIRAL D.K. TRIPATHI, *Chief of Naval Staff*

INDIA'S TOP MILITARY LEADERSHIP CAME TOGETHER for the first Combined Commanders' Conference since Operation Sindoor from September 15-17 at Fort William (now Vijay Durg), the Indian Army's Eastern Command headquarters in Kolkata. The presence of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, National Security Advisor Ajit Doval, Chief of Defence Staff (CDS) General Anil Chauhan and the three service chiefs underscored the significance of the event. For many, the stage was set for a grand announcement of the creation of Integrated Theatre Commands (ITCs)—that holy grail of transformative reform in the Indian military.

Events had built up to this point satisfactorily. In April 2024, Gen. Chauhan had submitted a proposal to the defence minister, laying out the plan to roll out the theatre commands, claiming that all three service chiefs had reached a consensus following months of dialogue. In September 2024, India had hosted its first Joint Commanders' Conference, where the army, navy and air force all appeared to rally behind the vision of a unified war-fighting structure in line with the One Border, One Force concept. A momentum seemed to have built up…till the Indian Air Force chief, Air Chief Marshal A.P. Singh, voiced his opposition to theatrisation in a public forum late last month.

Though the Kolkata conference took place against the backdrop of this apparent lack of cohesion, jointness got a firm vote of confidence from both PM Modi and Rajnath Singh. Modi directed the ministry of defence to "swiftly implement concrete steps to achieve greater jointness, *aatmanirbharta*, and innovation to meet future challenges". This was interpreted as a message to push forward the theatre command model despite internal disagreements. The conference also took firm steps towards theatrisation: a decision to form three joint military stations—with combined army, navy and IAF assets—each under the command of one of the three services. It can be seen as a dress rehearsal for the larger plan, or a glimpse of integrated tri-services units on a smaller scale. A decision was also taken to merge education branches of the three services into a single tri-services education corps.

WHAT IS A THEATRE COMMAND?

In a theatre command, units and assets of the army, navy and air force will be integrated over a certain geographic area, or theatre, under a single commander, with logistics, training and support services all woven into this single unit for optimum utilisation of resources and operational efficiency. With the commander having control over all warfighting assets across the three forces, including aircraft, helicopters, tanks,